

Rethinking Well-Being Beyond One-Size-Fits-All Solutions



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UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA

What is Well-Being?

Table 1 Commonly used definitions associated with emotional well-being of emotional well-being and related constructs reviewed in group discussions

Term	Definition	Source
Well-being (WB)	A top-down perspective on well-being, in which happy individuals are predicted to have more positive and adaptive responses to life events. Lyubomirsky has found that individuals that display positive well-being interpret situations and life events in ways that maintain (or promote) their general self-perception and sense of contentment	Lyubomirsky (2001)
WB	...no consensus...but general agreement that at minimum, (emotional) well-being includes the presence of positive emotions and moods (e.g., contentment, happiness), the absence of negative emotions (e.g., depression, anxiety), satisfaction with life, fulfillment and positive functioning. In simple terms, well-being can be described as judging life positively and feeling good	Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (2018)
SWB	People's overall evaluations of their lives and their emotional experiences. SWB thus includes broad appraisals, such as life satisfaction and health satisfaction judgments, and specific feelings that reflect how people are reacting to the events and circumstances in their lives	Diener et al., (2018)
SWB	... a cognition process of satisfaction or happiness, which is derived from optimal functioning. Can be classified into subjective vs. objective elements; subjective components involve personal and psychological factors such as belief system and contentment, and objective components involve external factors such as income, neighborhood safety, and community support	(Lindert et al., 2015)
SWB	... made up of somewhat independent elements, including positive and negative affect, and life satisfaction; these aspects should all be studied individually. It is defined as the evaluation one has on their life, therefore focuses on many variables such as self-perception, life experience, emotional reactions (Diener et al., 2003)	(Diener et al., 2018)
Subjective well-being (SWB)/ EWB (used interchangeably)	...refers to how people experience the quality of their lives and includes both emotional reactions and cognitive judgments. It has three components: (1) eudaimonia ((2) life satisfaction or evaluative well-being; and (3) hedonic or affectual or experiential well-being. SWB here is defined as synonymous with EWB	National Institutes of Health, (2018a)
EWB	Not synonymous with the absence of illness, nor synonymous with mental health. EWB... is an umbrella label for several related psychometrically defined concepts, including psychological well-being, positive mental health, health-related quality of life, thriving, and subjective well-being. These concepts encompass several psychological dimensions, including positive emotions and moods (e.g., happiness); the relative absence of negative emotions, moods, and states (e.g., stress, sadness, loneliness); life satisfaction; sense of meaning and purpose; quality of life; and satisfaction with other life domains (e.g., work satisfaction, satisfaction with relationships)	(Feller et al. and University of California Los Angeles Community Translational Science Team, 2018)
Flourishing	has five components: positive emotions, a general feeling of contentment; engagement, a state of flow in activities; relationships, a supportive and valuable support network; meaning, a sense of purpose; and accomplishment, a feeling of achievement	(Seligman, 2011)

Table 1 (continued)

Term	Definition	Source
Psychological well-being (PWB)	Six elements: • Autonomy—sense of individuality; self-evaluation based on personal standards rather than others • Personal growth—continuously developing and seeing potential in oneself • Self-acceptance—holding positive attitudes of oneself; a positive self-perception • Purpose in life—sense of direction and purpose within one's life • Positive relations with others—having good relationships with others; feeling capable of love and empathy • Environmental mastery—ability to choose environments that make one the most comfortable and secure	Ryff (1989)
EWB	Umbrella label for several related psychometrically defined concepts, including psychological well-being, positive mental health, health-related quality of life, thriving, and subjective well-being. The definition of EWB encompasses satisfaction with relationships, the subjective perception of social support. Also closely entwined are the structural aspects of social relationships (e.g., extent of social integration, size of social networks)	(Feller et al. and University of California Los Angeles Community Translational Science Team, 2018)
EWB	.. consists of three components: positive affect and negative affect (i.e., affective evaluations), and life satisfaction (i.e., cognitive evaluation)	Lyubomirsky and Lepper (1999)
EWB	...an overall positive state of one's emotions, life satisfaction, sense of meaning and purpose, and ability to pursue self-defined goals (Feller et al, 2018). Elements...include a sense of balance in emotion, thoughts, social relationships, and pursuits, or lack thereof. The relative importance of each construct will vary across subpopulations and developmental stages. Currently, fundamental consensus concerning the definition and components of emotional well-being, as well as what interventions promote emotional well-being, either as a mediator of health outcomes or as an end in itself, is lacking	National Institutes of Health, (2018b)
EWB	...feeling more of a pleasant effect (positive affect) than unpleasant effect (negative affect) in one's life overall, including past, present, and future perceptions (Reh et al., 2021)	(Reh et al., 2021)
EWB	People's positive moods and emotions and low levels of negative moods and emotions, and reflects not only momentary enjoyment, but also movement toward goals that are congruent with a person's motives	Fredrickson and Joiner (2002)

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Flourishing	has five components: positive emotions, a general feeling of contentment, engagement, a state of flow in activities; relationships, a support network; a valuable support network; meaning, a sense of purpose; and achievement, a feeling of achievement	

Well-being as an umbrella term

Well-being as defined by its “Ingredients”

Well-being as a measure of functioning

Well-Being as an Umbrella

“EWB... is an **umbrella label** for several related psychometrically defined concepts, including psychological well-being, positive mental health, health-related quality of life, thriving, and subjective well-being.”

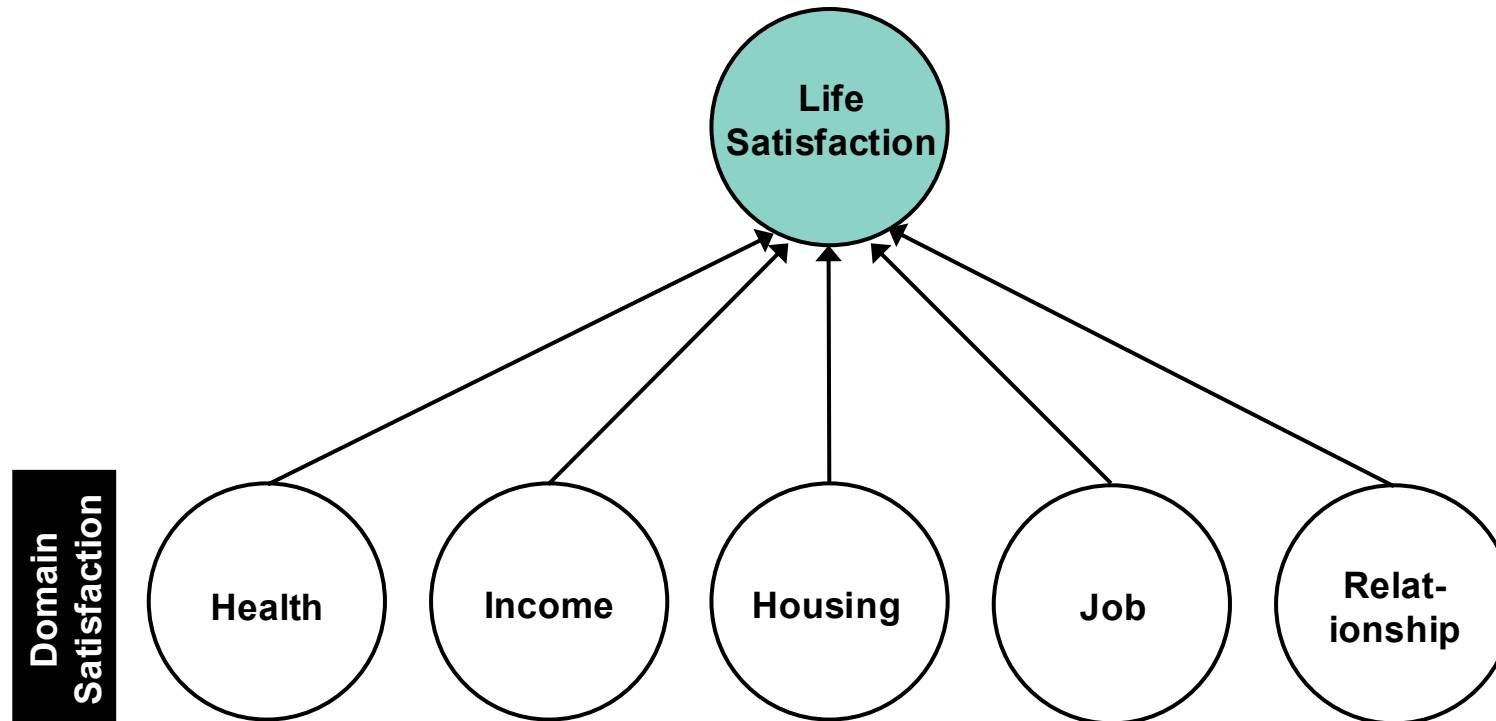


National Institutes of Health, (2018a)

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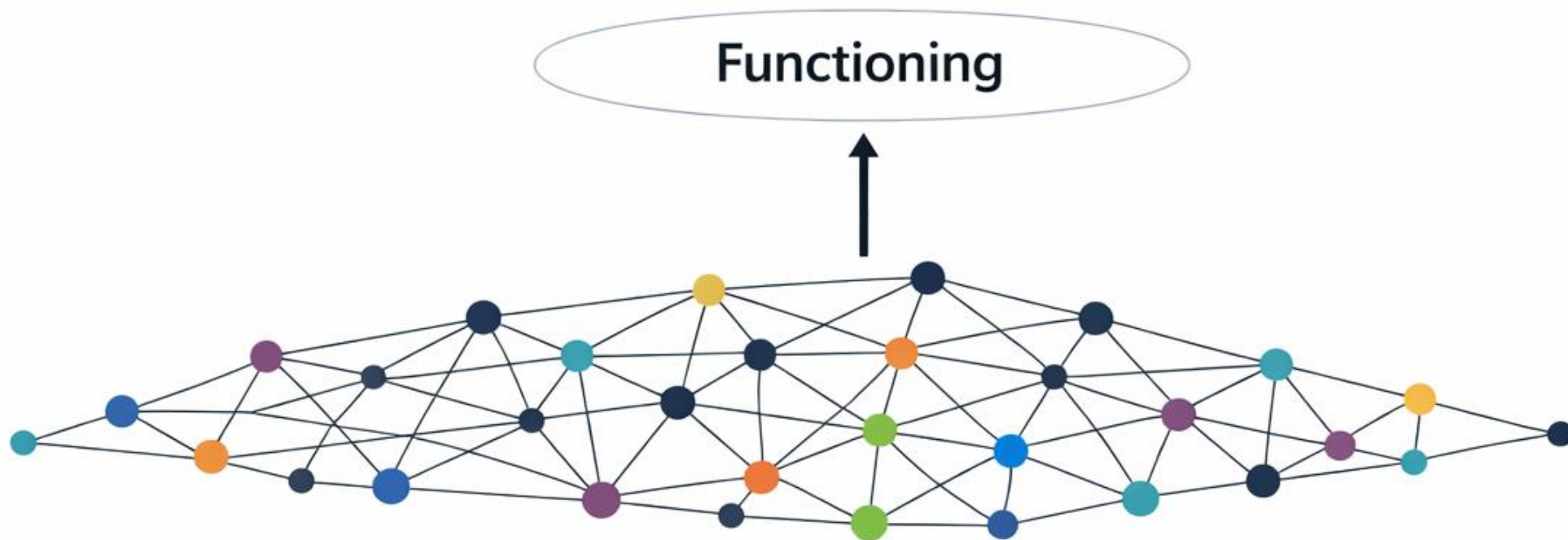
Well-Being as Ingredients

“**Elements**...include a sense of balance in emotion, thoughts, social relationships, and pursuits, or lack thereof. The **relative importance** of each construct will vary across subpopulations and developmental stages. Currently, fundamental consensus concerning the definition and **components**... is lacking”



Well-Being as Functioning

“Wellbeing can be understood as how people feel and how they **function** both on a personal and social level, and how they evaluate their lives as a **whole**.”



Well-Being is Consequential

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RESEARCH ARTICLE

Alzheimer's & Dementia®
THE JOURNAL OF THE ALZHEIMER'S ASSOCIATION

Personality predictors of dementia diagnosis and neuropathological burden: An individual participant data meta-analysis

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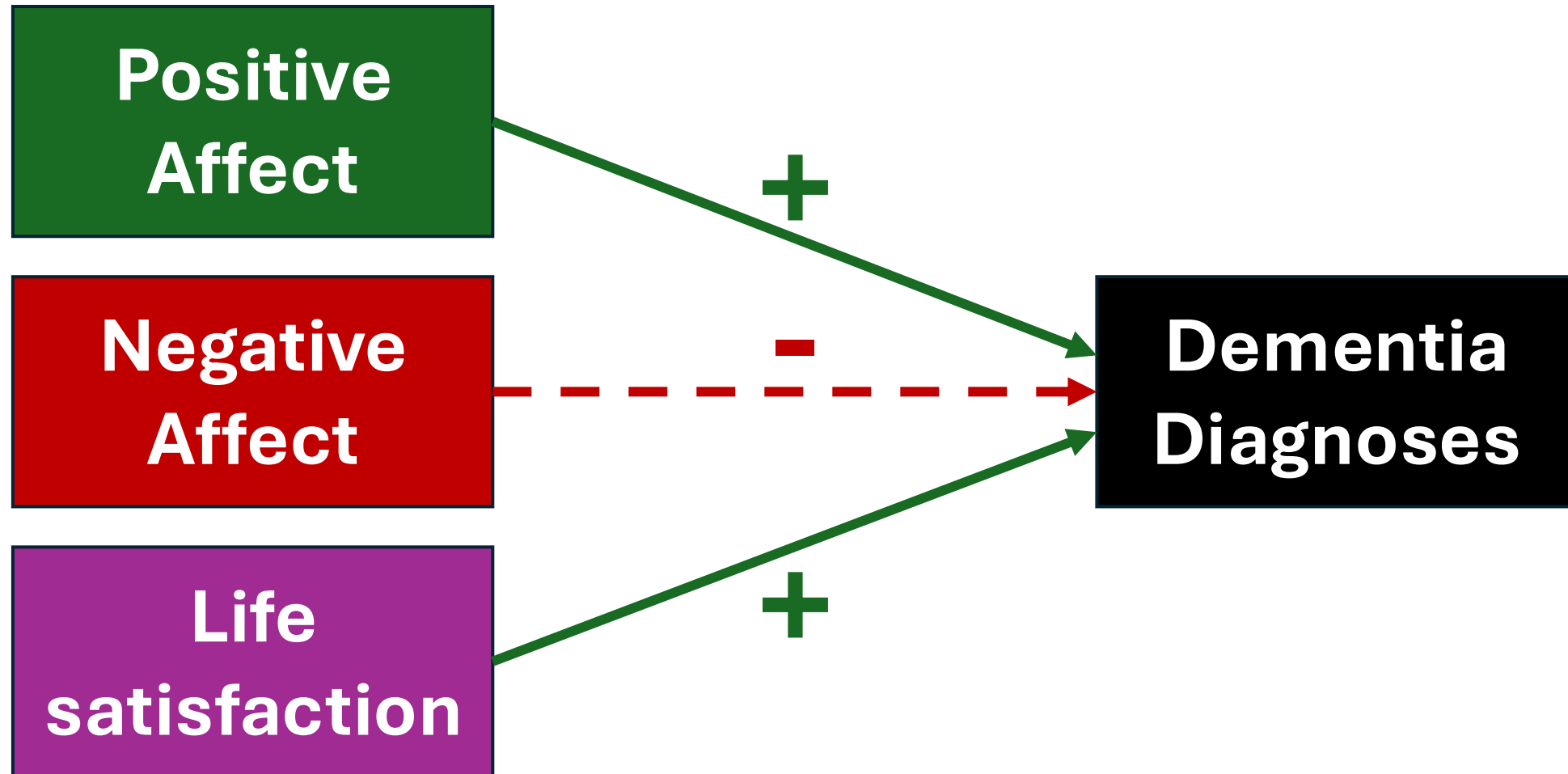
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Beck et al. (2023), *Alzheimer's & Dementia*

Well-Being is Consequential



How do we reduce ill-being?
How do we improve well-being?

How do we improve well-being?

Two common strategies:

Psychology's approach: What works for *most* people?

Lay approach: What worked for someone who improved their well-being?

How do we improve well-being?

What do people with high well-being do?

What is similar about people with high well-being?



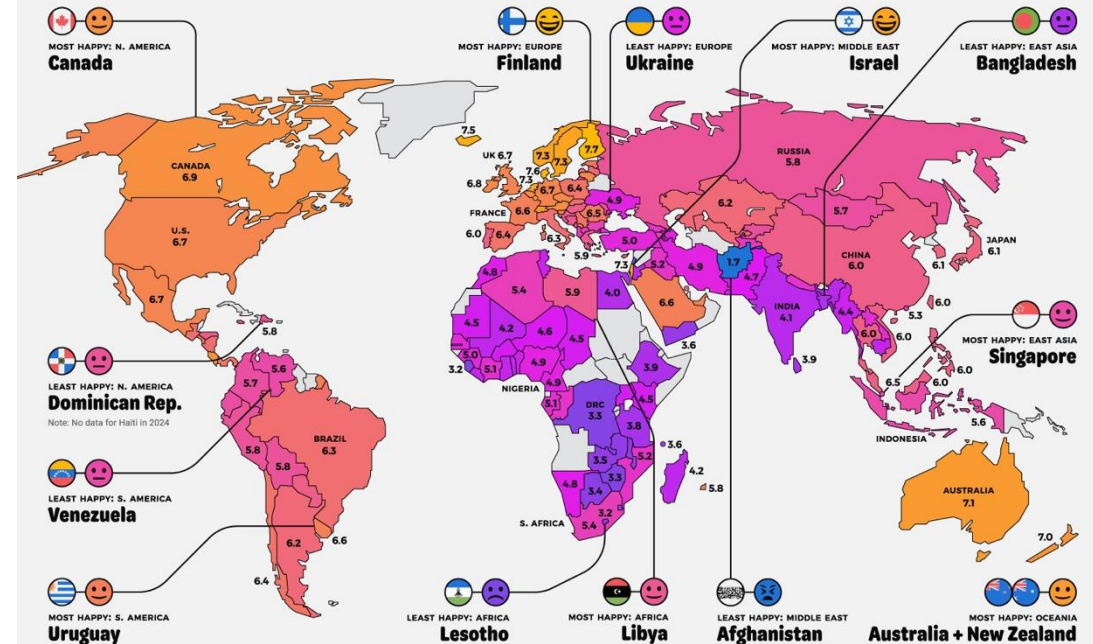
The logo for the World Happiness Report, featuring a stylized 'W' and 'H' in white. The 'W' is composed of two triangles, and the 'H' is composed of two squares. The 'R' is a simple, bold letter. The background is a gradient of purple and blue.

World Happiness Report

Happiness Levels

The Gallup World Poll asks respondents in each country to rate their current life on a scale from 0–10, ranking from highest to lowest.

Each country is scored out of 10 based on self-reported measures of well-being and happiness. See the [World Happiness Report 2024](#) for the full methodology.



Note: Scores are based on individuals' own assessments of their lives, in particular their answers to the single-item Cantril ladder life-evaluation question.



Source: World Happiness Report 2024



COLLABORATORS RESEARCH + WRITING Pallavi Rao | ART DIRECTION + DESIGN Sabrina Lam

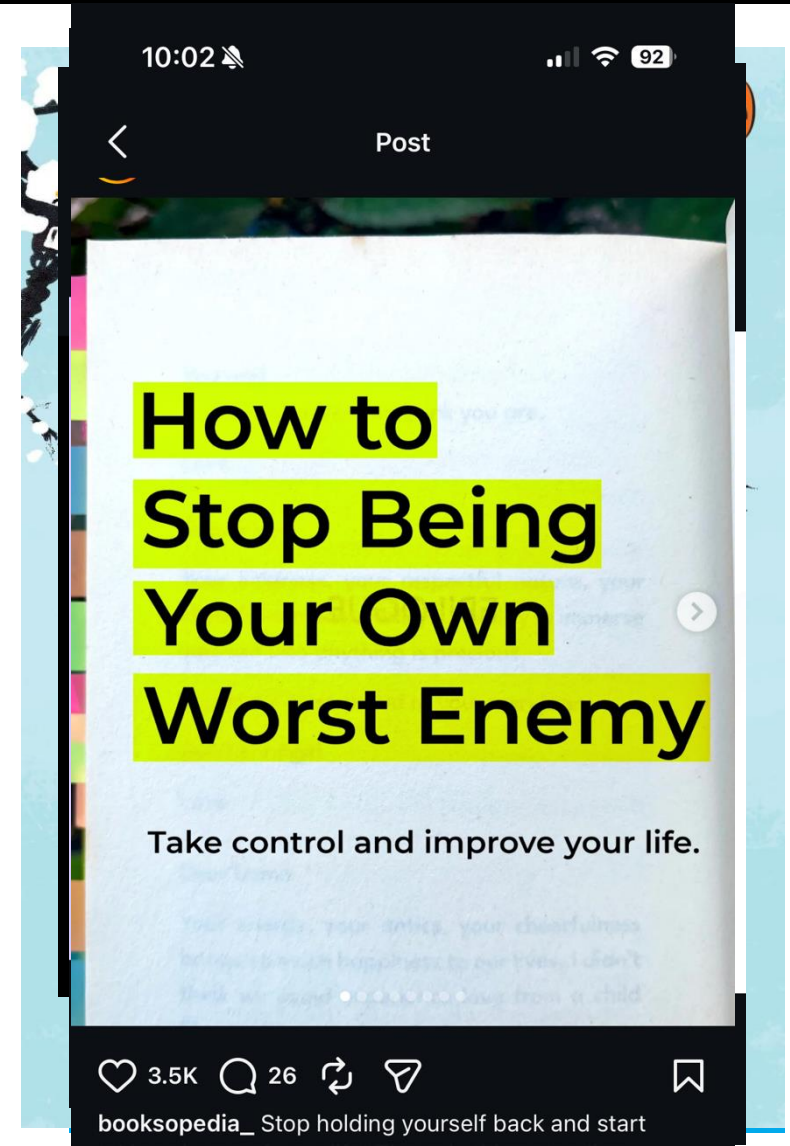
How do we improve well-being?



1	Having someone to count on
2	Log GDP per capita
3	Healthy life expectancy
4	Freedom to make life choices
5	Generosity
6	Freedom from corruption

How do we improve well-being?

- The self-help industry is estimated to be \$12 billion annually
- Wellness influencer global market was \$6.32 trillion in 2023



How do we improve well-being?

**Both are wrong and ignore how
we differ from each other.**

Everyday approach: What worked for someone who improved
their well-being?

Outline

**Well-being is consequential for health, work,
and life**

**Well-being is personal / personalized (i.e. not
one-size-fits all)**

**Well-being is not an individual responsibility
(or a moral issue/failing)**

**What promotes your well-being may change
over time**

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Well-being is personal / personalized (i.e. not one-size-fits all)

nature human behaviour

Article

<https://doi.org/10.1038/s41562-025-02171-z>

Towards a personalized happiness approach to capturing change in satisfaction

Received: 16 June 2023

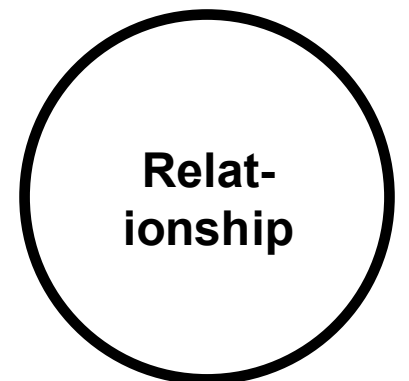
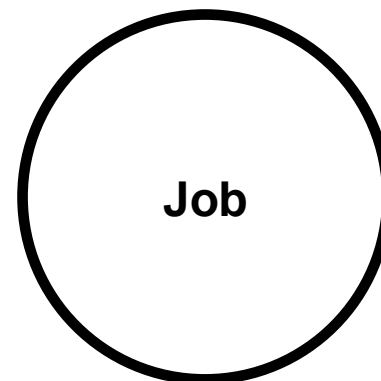
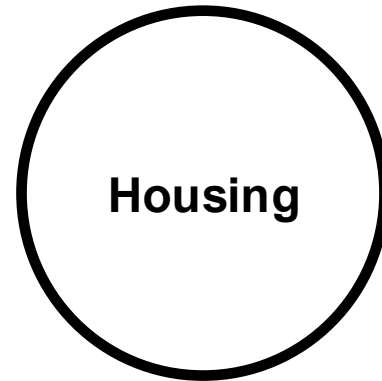
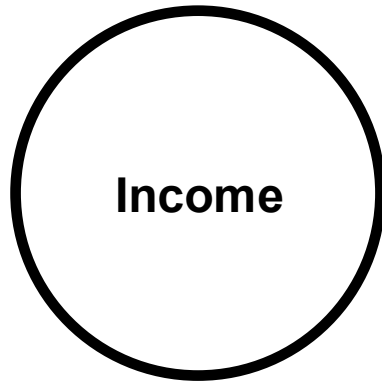
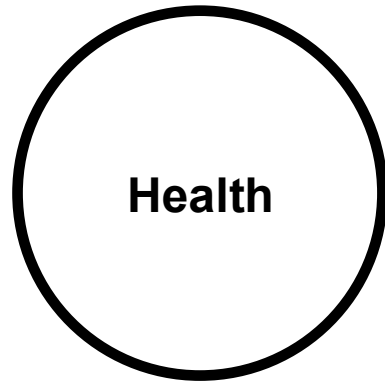
Accepted: 12 March 2025

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 Check for updates

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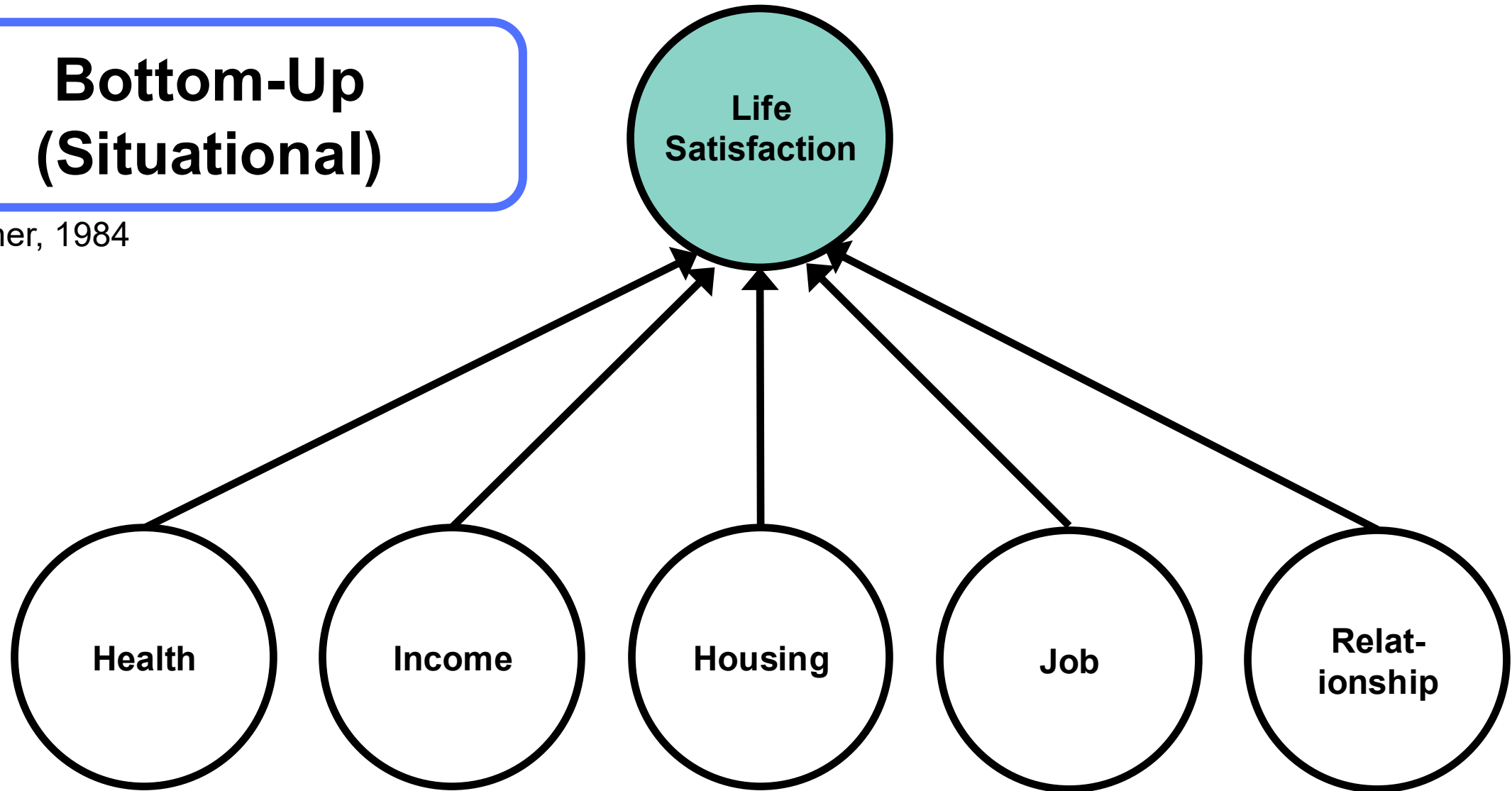
Contemporary approaches examining the determinants of happiness have posited that happiness is determined bidirectionally by both top-down, global life satisfaction and bottom-up, domain satisfaction processes. We propose a personalized happiness perspective, suggesting that the



**Domain
Satisfaction**

Bottom-Up (Situational)

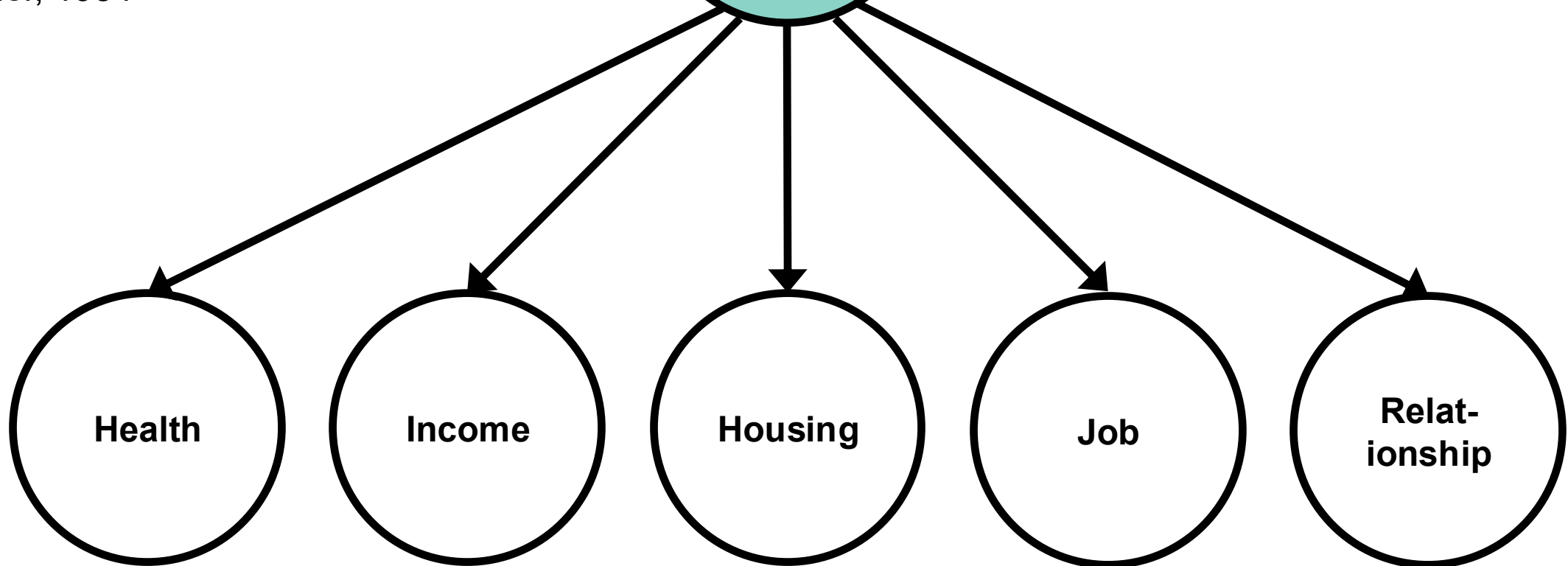
Diener, 1984



Beck et al. (2025, *NHB*)

Top-Down (Spill-over)

Diener, 1984

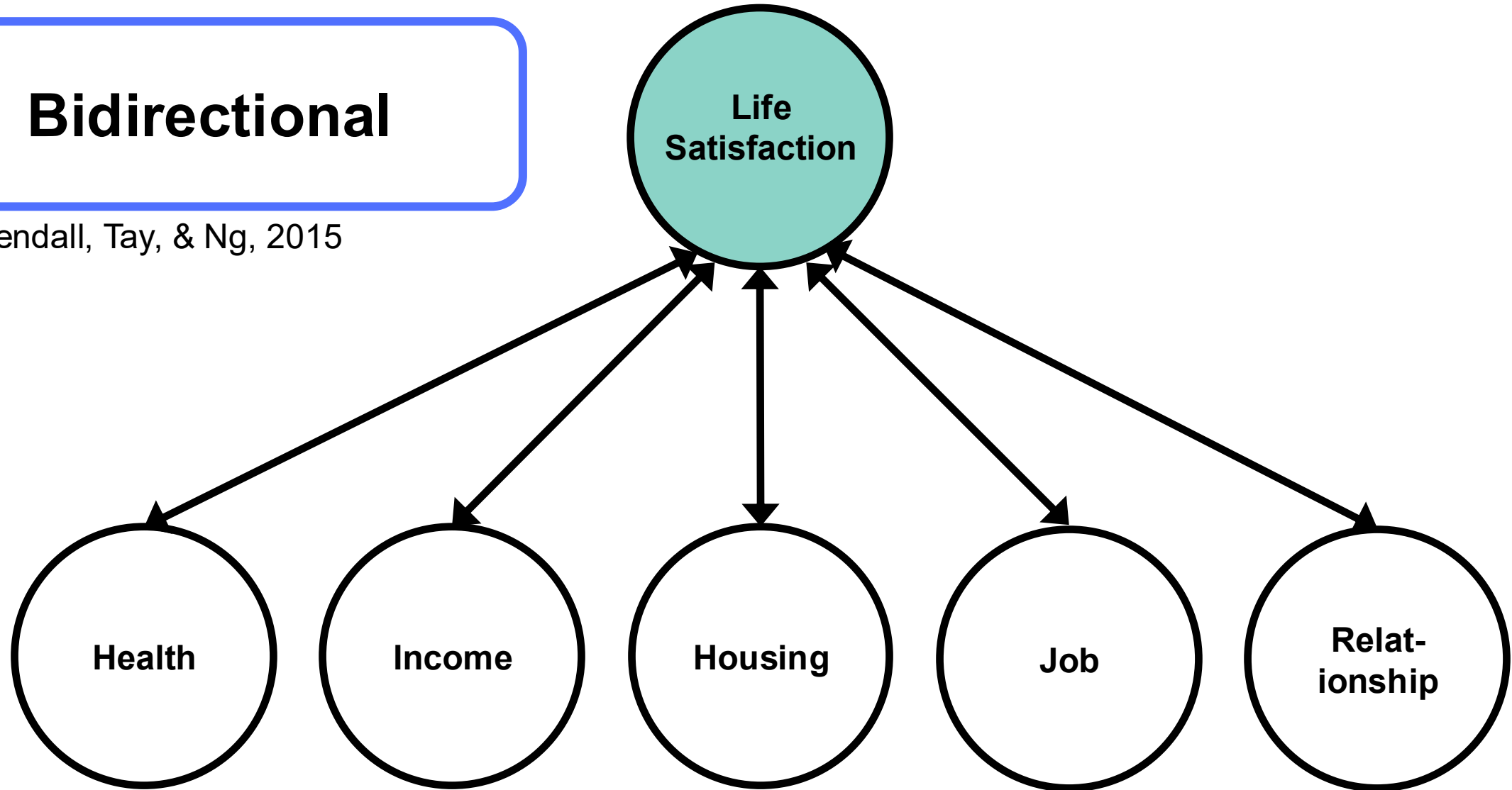


Domain
Satisfaction

Beck et al. (2025, *NHB*)

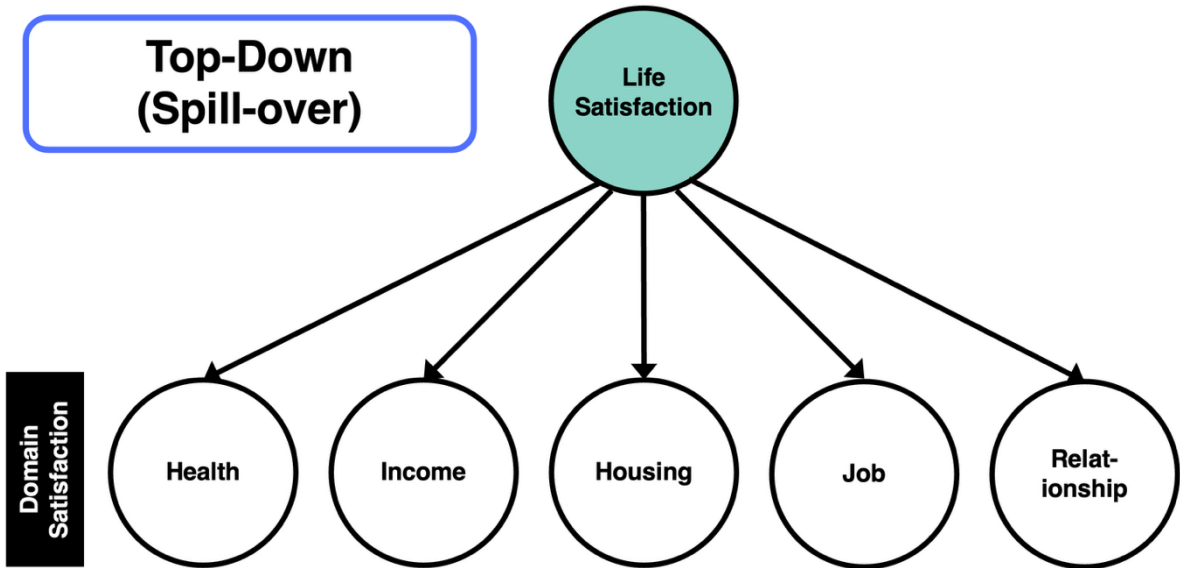
Bidirectional

Kuykendall, Tay, & Ng, 2015



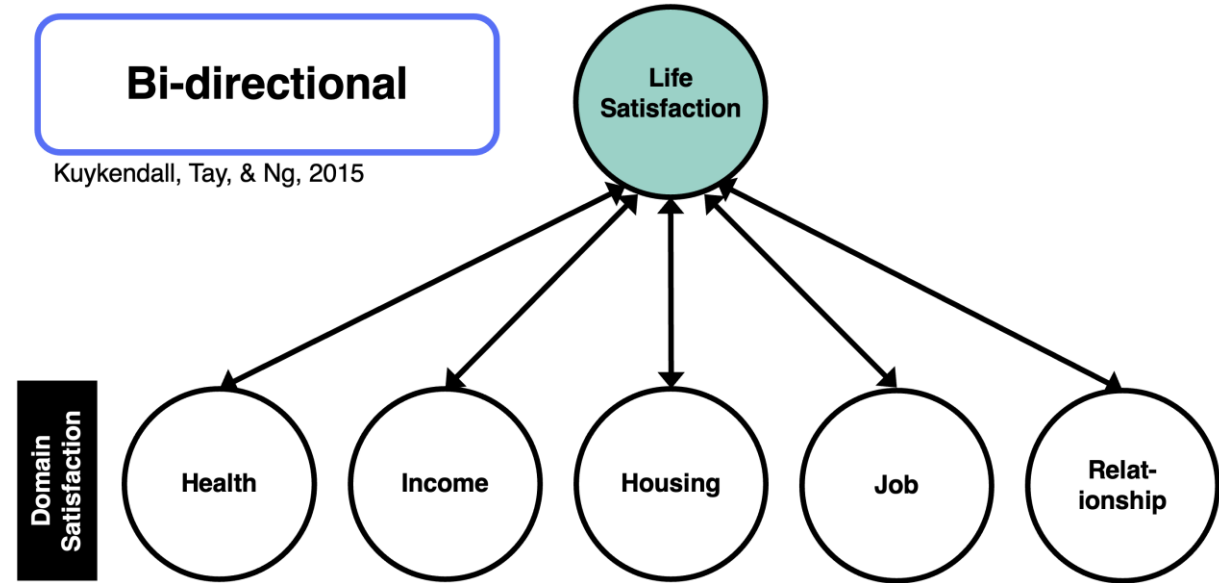
Beck et al. (2025, *NHB*)

**Top-Down
(Spill-over)**

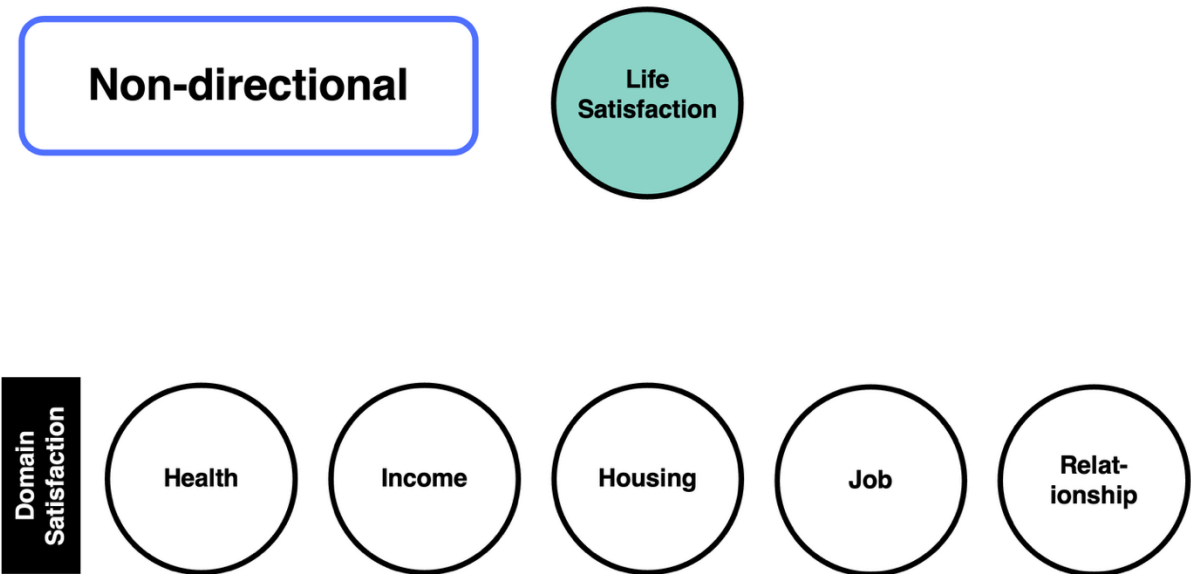


Bi-directional

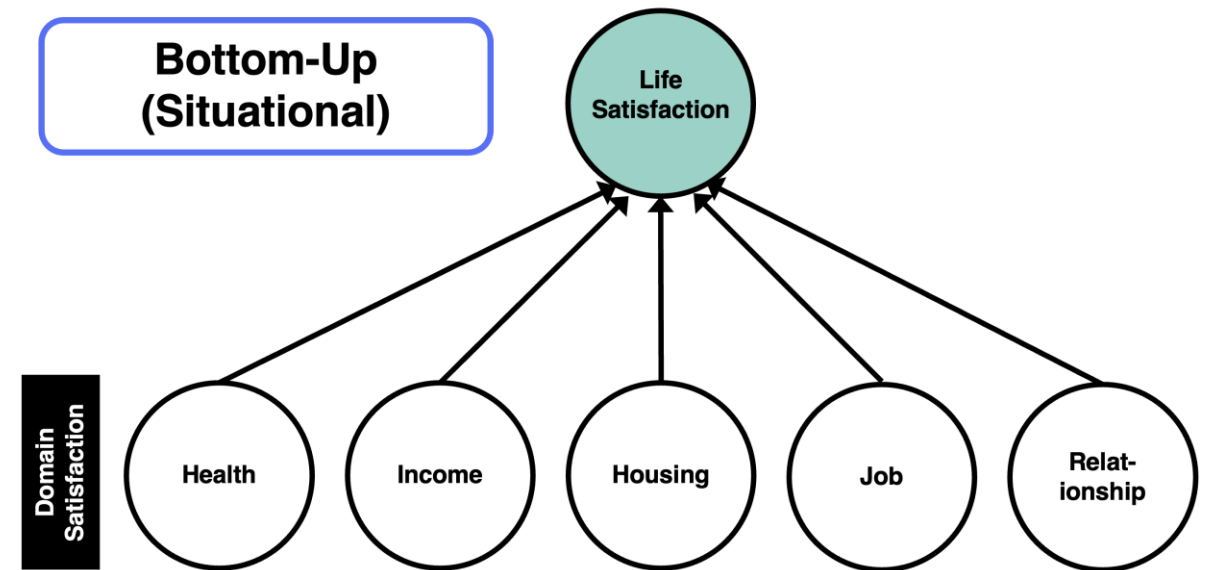
Kuykendall, Tay, & Ng, 2015



Non-directional

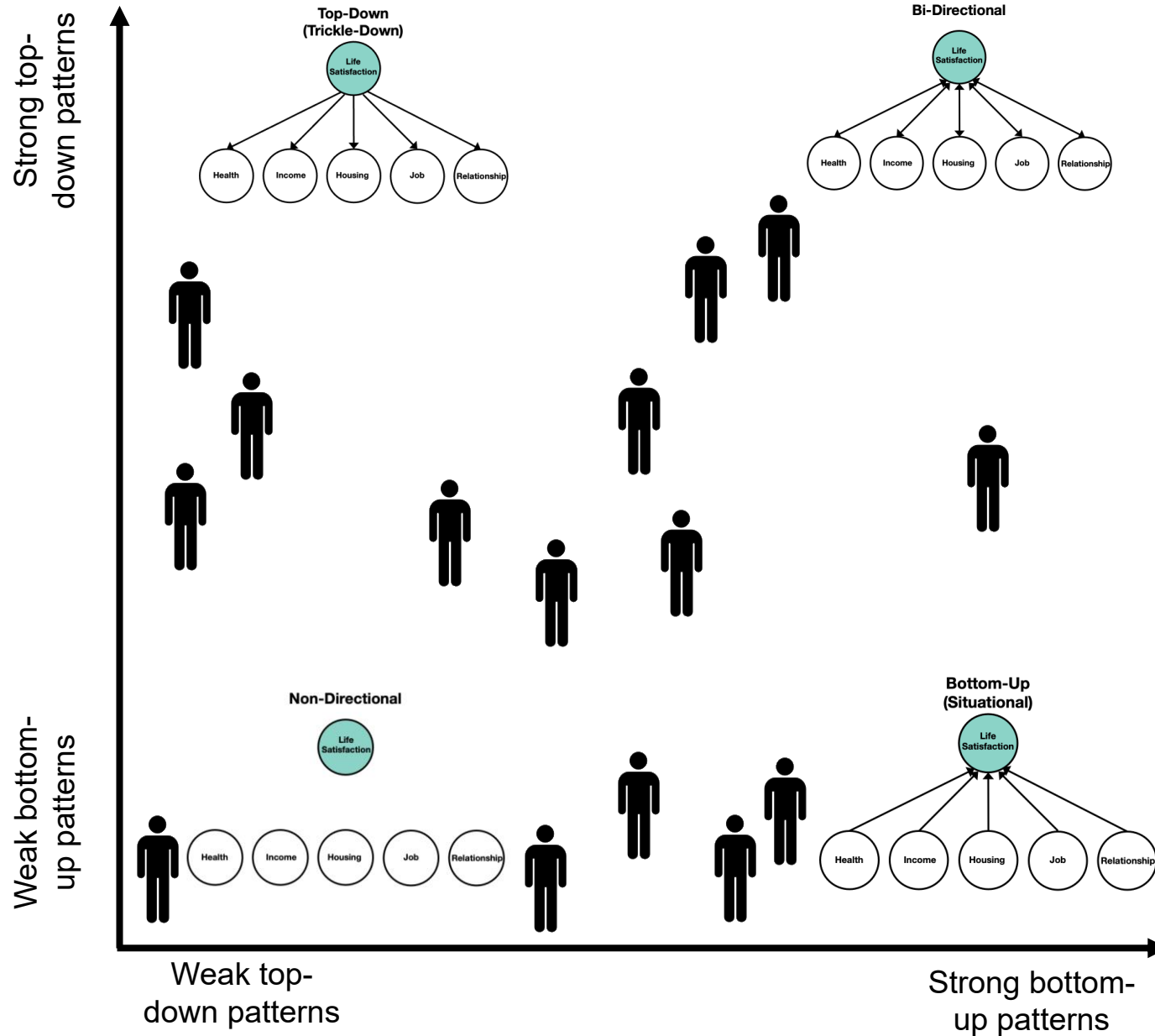


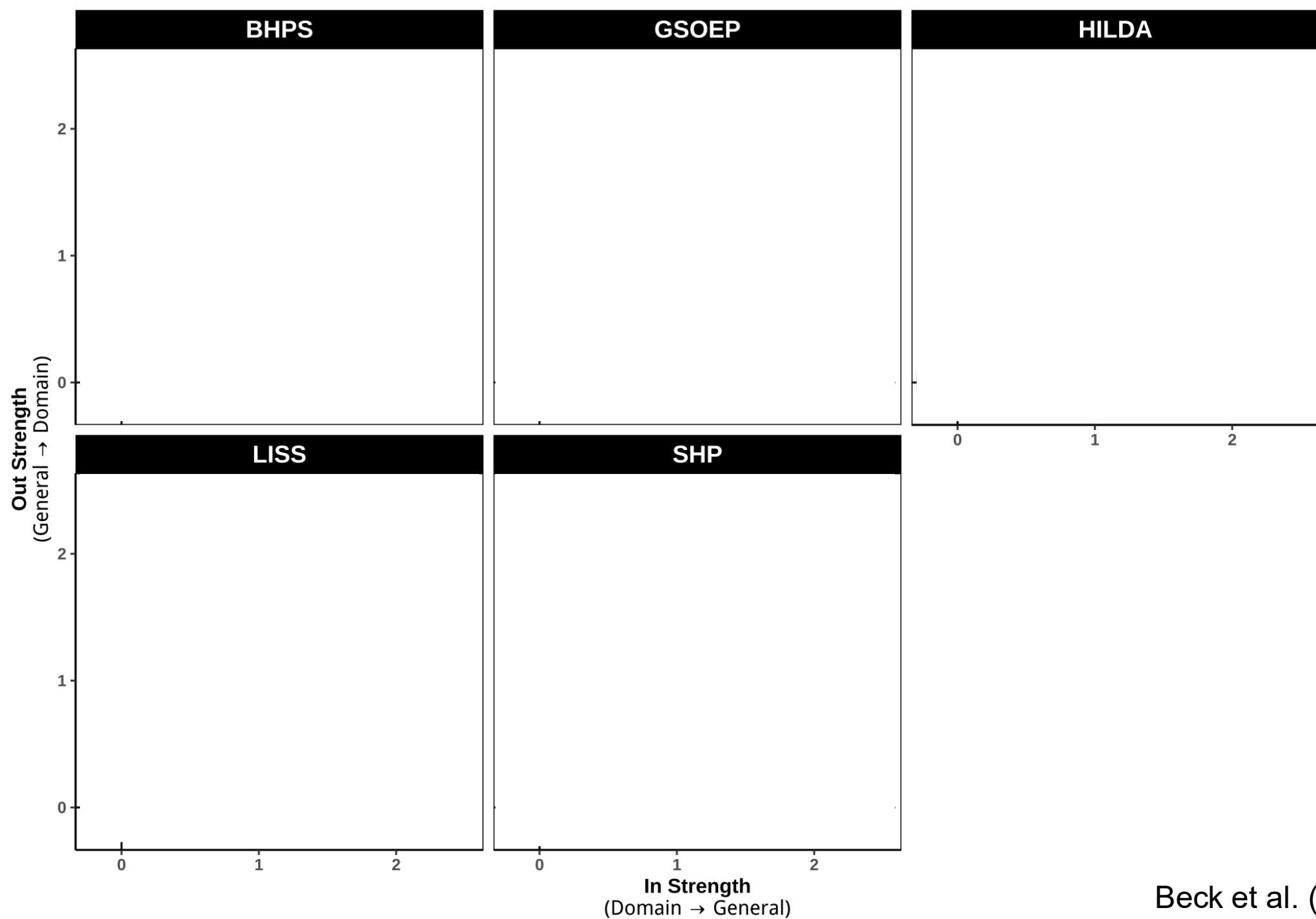
**Bottom-Up
(Situational)**

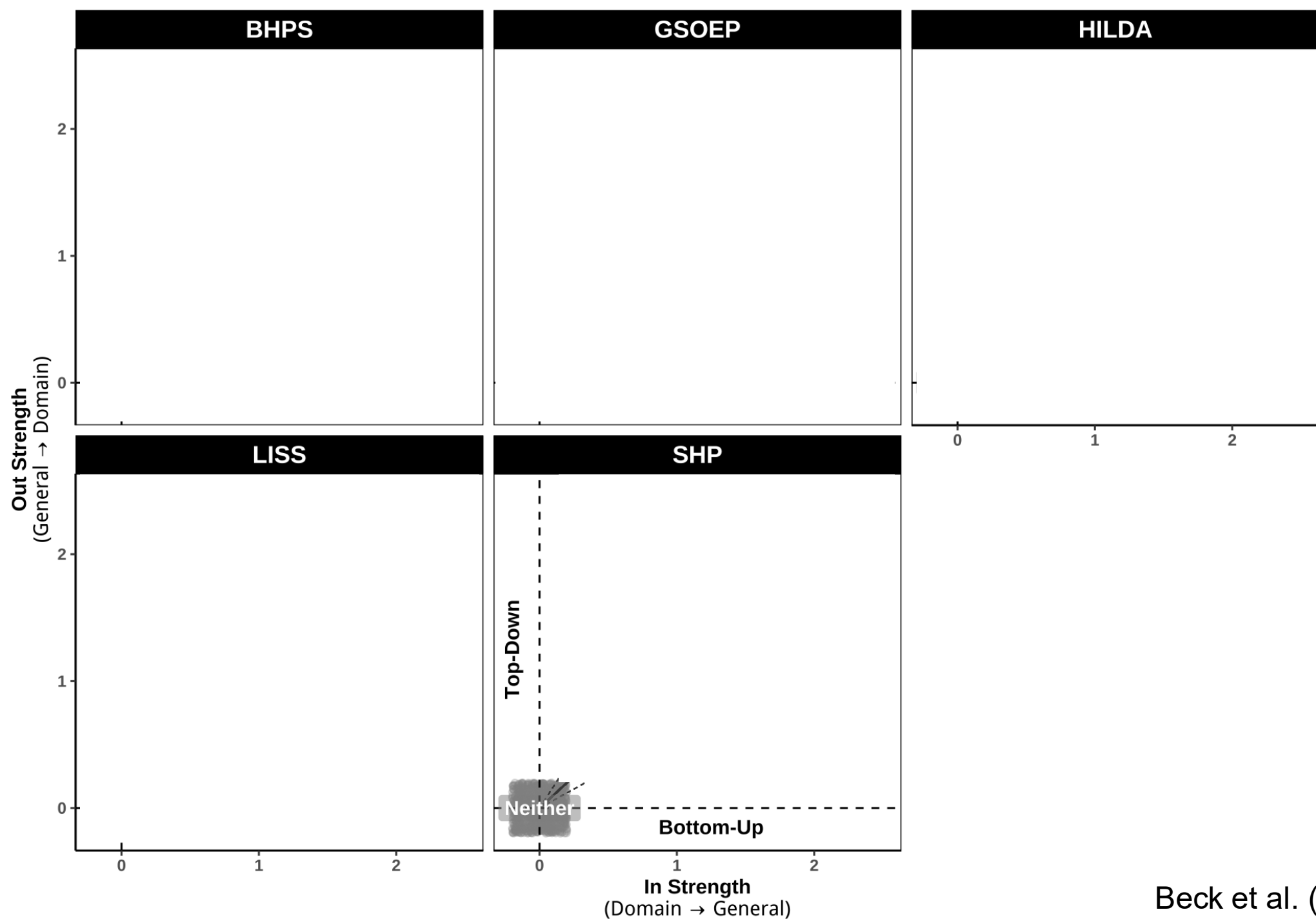


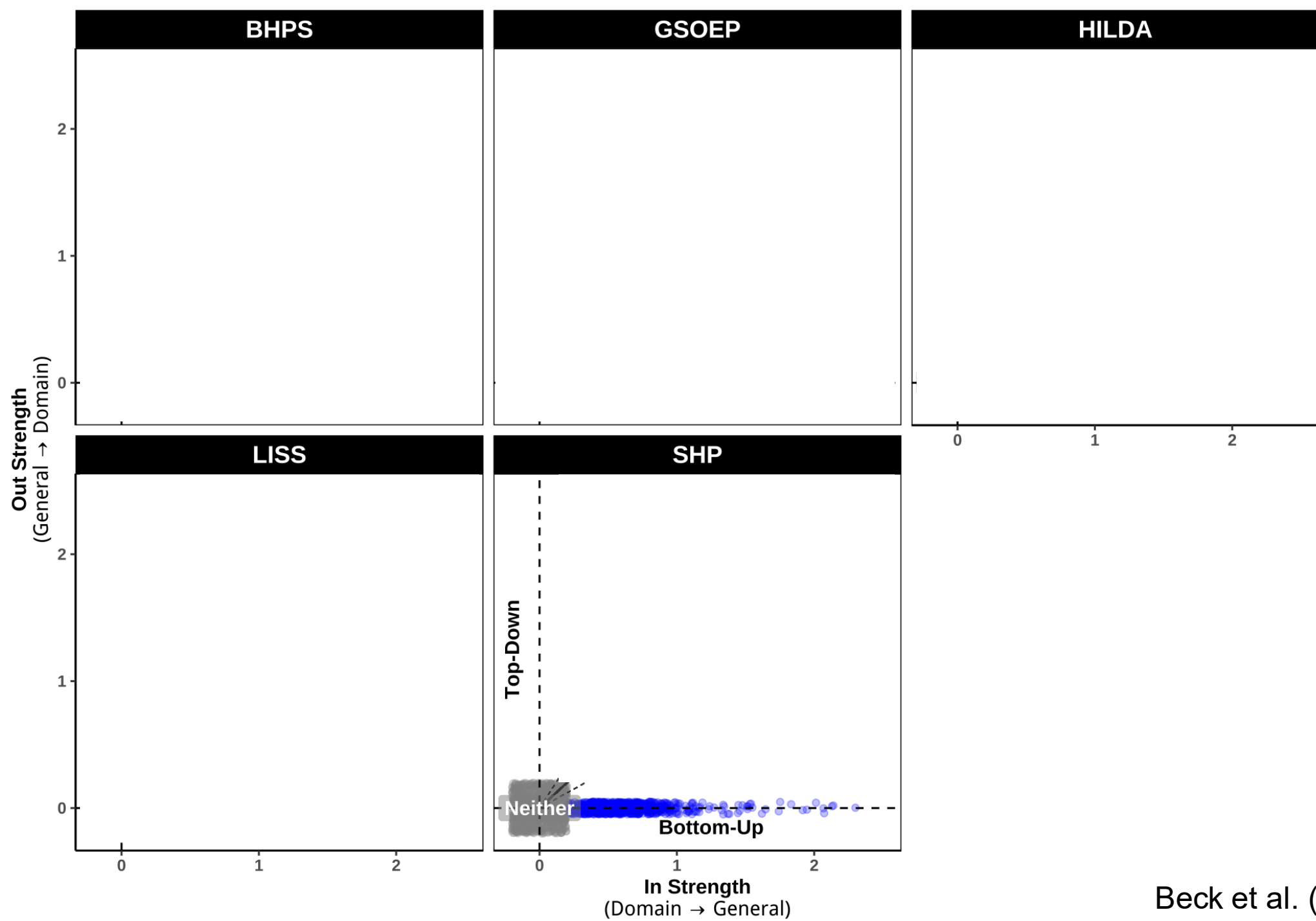
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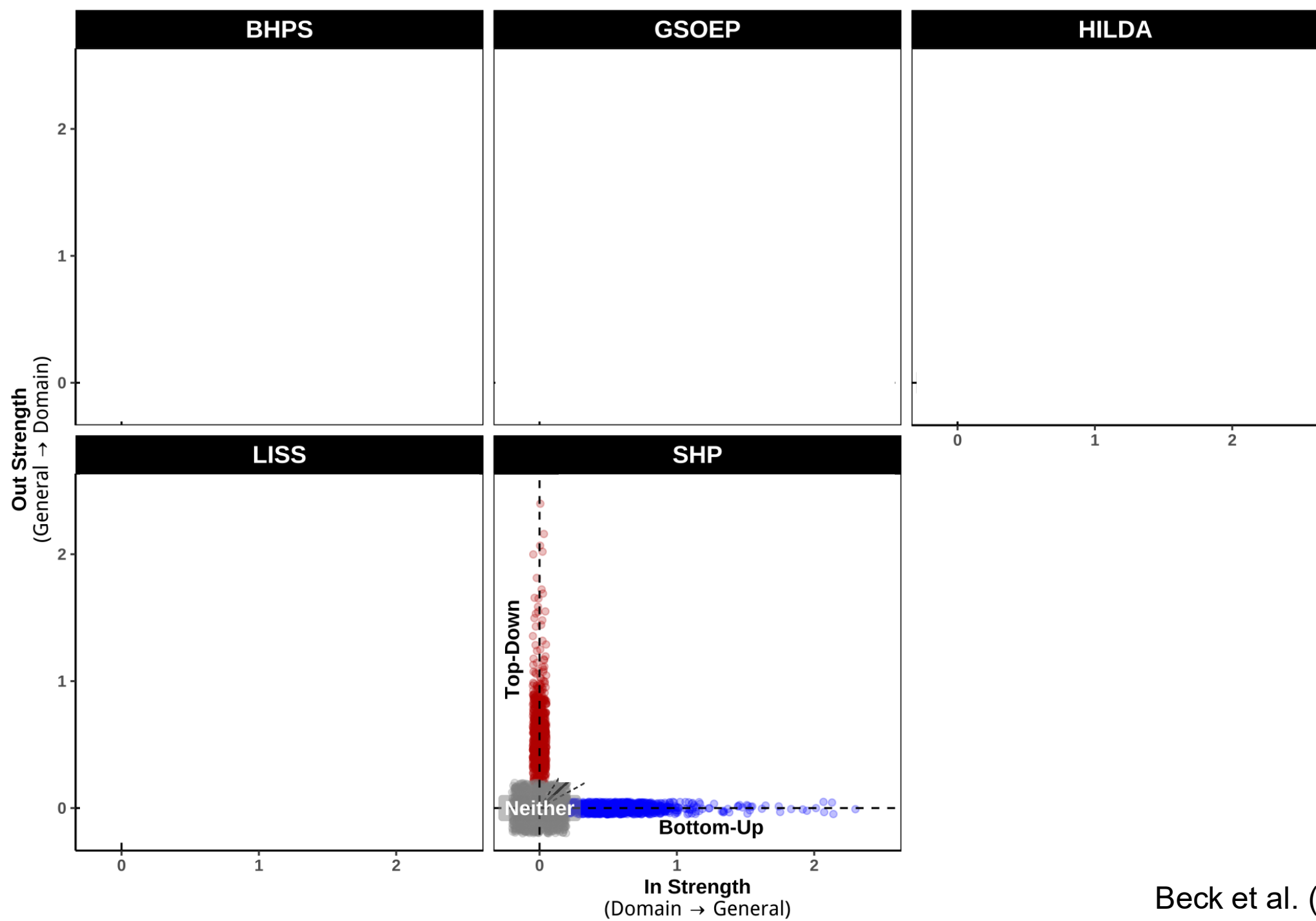
Personalised Perspectives on Happiness: For whom is each theory correct?

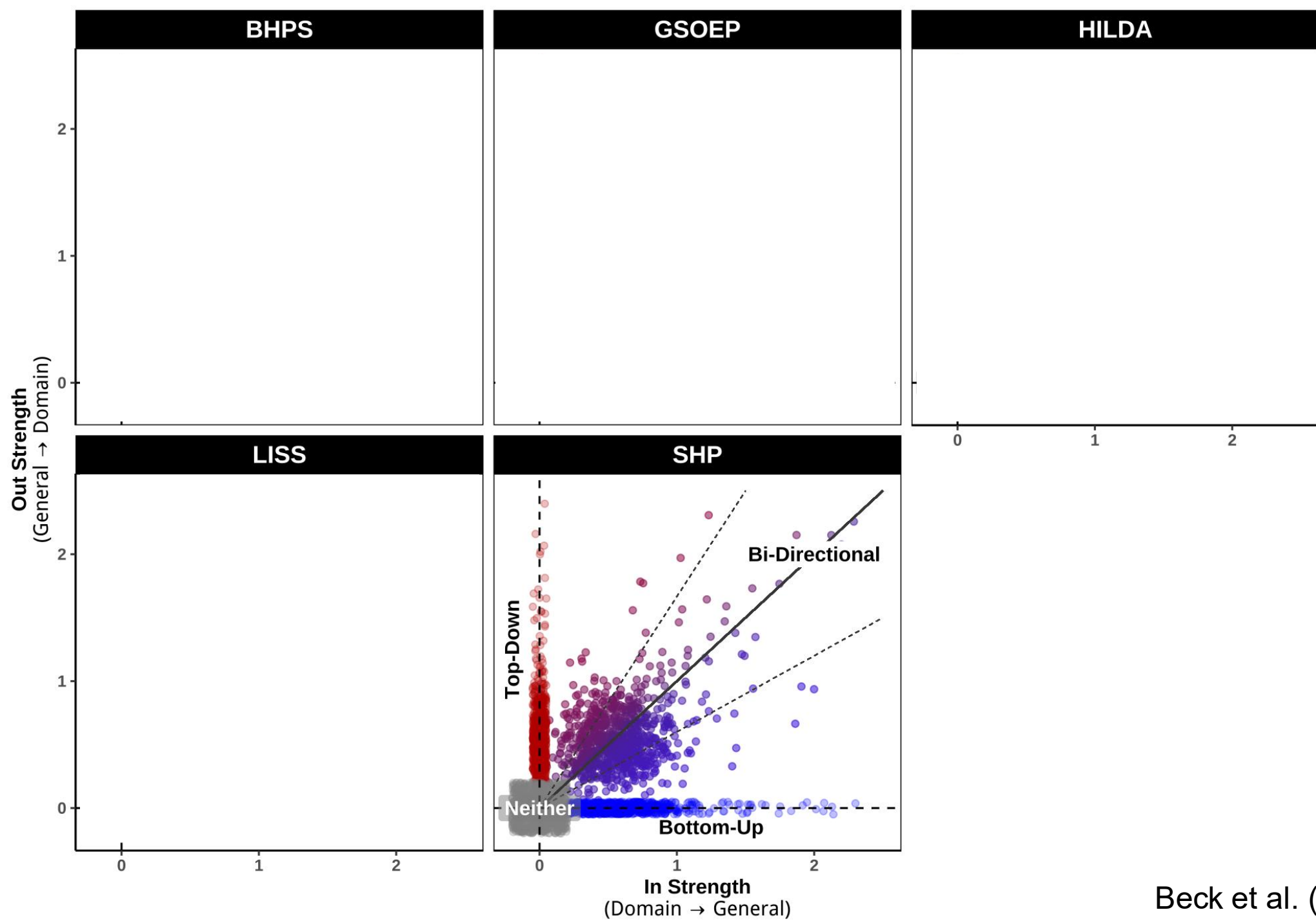


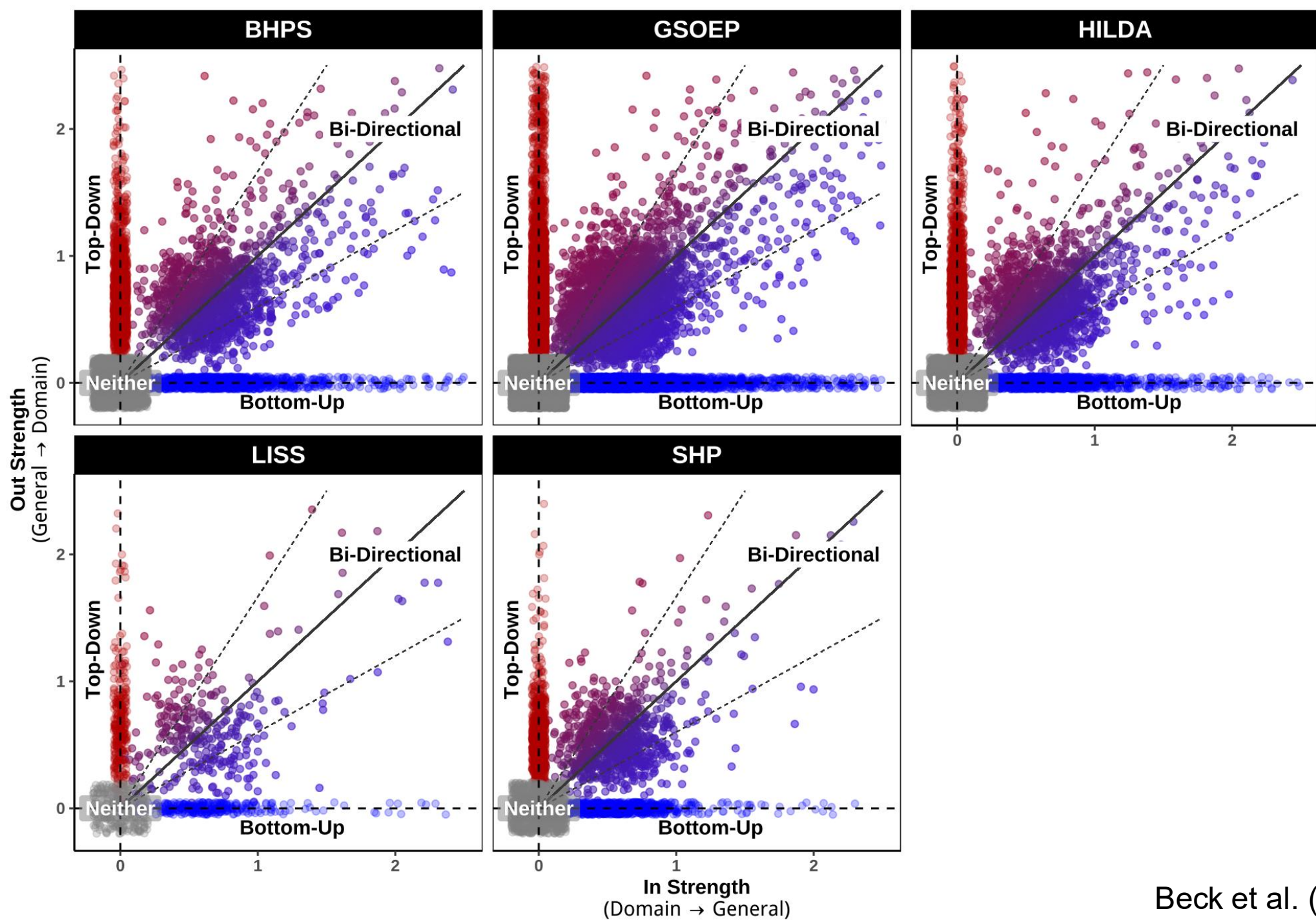


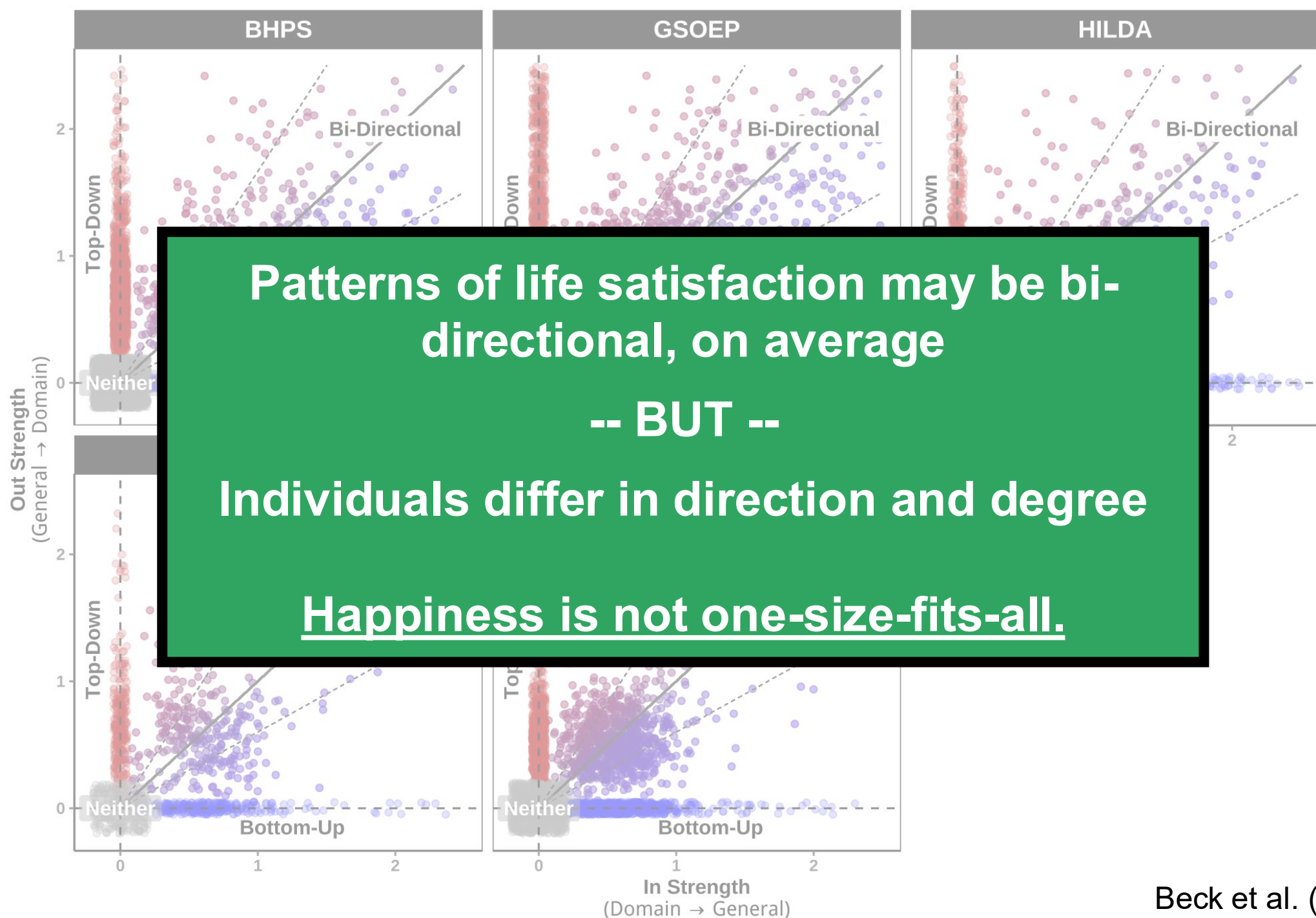










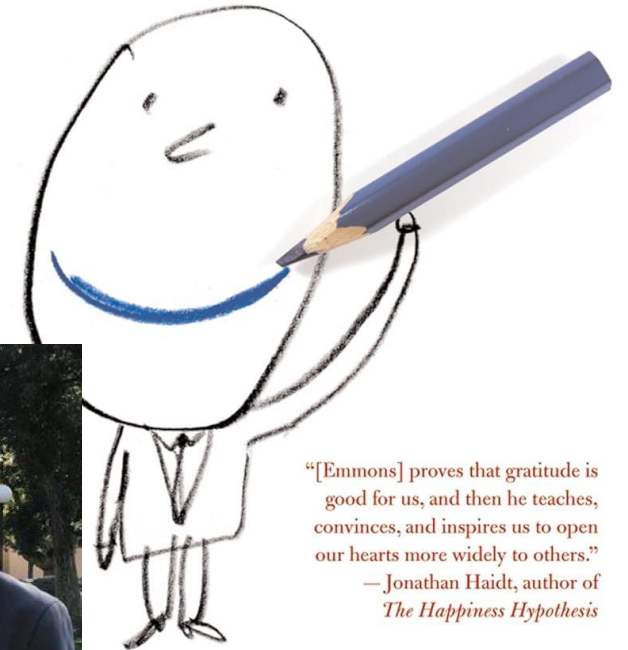


Well-being is personal / personalized (i.e. not one-size-fits all)

- **Top-down strategies:**
 - **Examples:** therapy, gratitude journals, mindfulness;
 - **Goal:** change from the inside out
- **Bottom-up strategies:**
 - **Examples:** check in with relationships, check in with job expectations and work-life balance
 - **Goal:** change from the outside in

Thanks!

How Practicing Gratitude
Can Make You Happier



"[Emmons] proves that gratitude is good for us, and then he teaches, convinces, and inspires us to open our hearts more widely to others."
— Jonathan Haidt, author of *The Happiness Hypothesis*



ROBERT A. EMMONS, PH.D.
Professor Emeritus, UC Davis

**Do you think you're more top-down,
bottom-up, or bi-directional?**

Well-being is personal / personalized (i.e. not one-size-fits all)

- All those self-help books may not help *you*
- And that's not your fault
- Many make an unreasonable assumption – that what worked for them should work for you

**Think of time you took well-meaning advice
to improve your well-being, but it didn't
work. How did you feel?**

Outline

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**What promotes your well-being may change
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Well-being is not an individual responsibility (or a moral issue/failing)

- Culture and well-being are deeply intertwined
- Culture shapes our *values* and *goals*

What Makes a Good Life in the U.S. and Japan?



UNITED STATES

- ✝ Faith / Spirituality
- 🏆 Personal Achievement
- 📈 Financial Success

Younger adults were more likely to value having a good job.

SHARED VALUES

- 👤 Family Relationships with Family
- 👥 Good Friendships
- 🌱 Health and Wellbeing
- ⚖️ A Sense of Purpose

- Family Relationships
- Good Friendships
- Health and Wellbeing



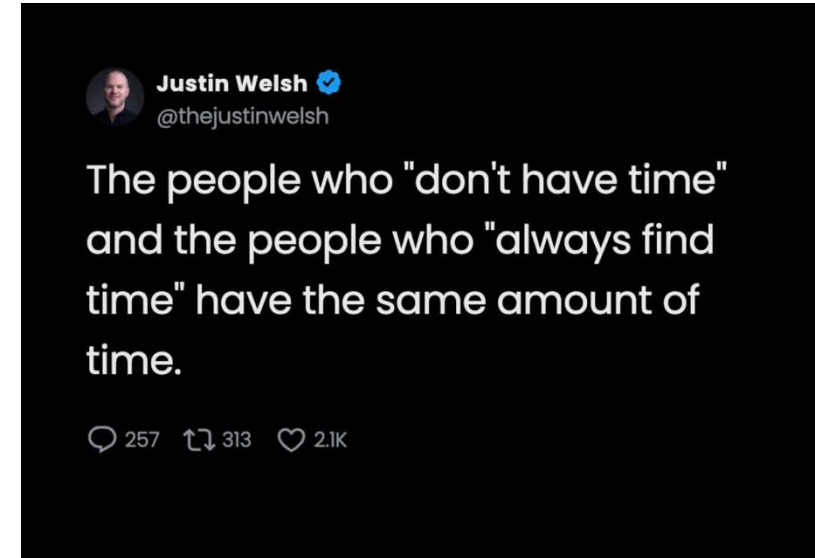
JAPAN

- 👤 Harmony with Others
- 🌳 Connection to Nature
- 🤝 Contributing to Society

Younger adults were more likely to value having a good job.

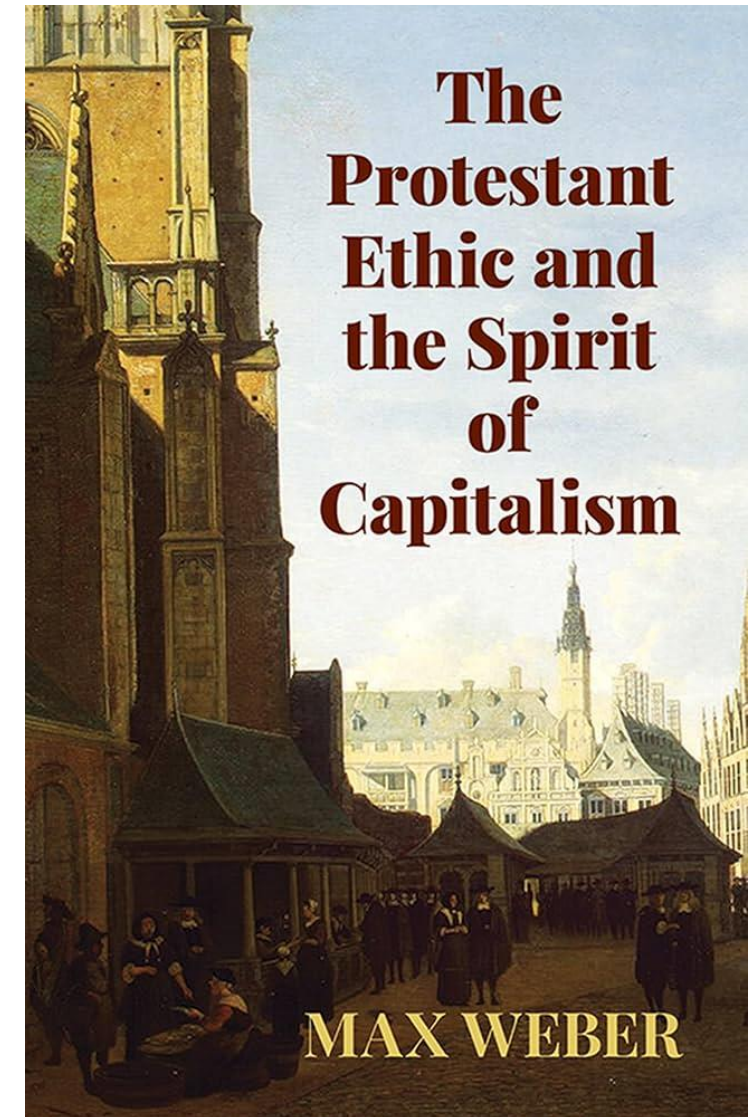
Well-being is not an individual responsibility (or a moral issue/failing)

- Individualism makes well-being feel like it's our fault
 - “we all have the same 24 hours”
- But this ignores structural factors
 - Wealth gaps
 - Caretaking
 - Commutes
 - Health



Well-being is not an individual responsibility (or a moral issue/failing)

- Well-being has been *moralized*
- *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*
 - “pull yourself up by your bootstraps”



Internal

External

Well-Being



```
graph TD; Internal[Internal] --> WellBeing[Well-Being]; External[External] --> WellBeing;
```

The diagram consists of three rectangular boxes. At the top left is a blue box with the word 'Internal' in white. At the top right is a blue box with the word 'External' in white. Below these two boxes, centered horizontally, is a larger black box with the words 'Well-Being' in white. A black arrow points from the bottom center of the 'Internal' box to the top left corner of the 'Well-Being' box. Another black arrow points from the bottom center of the 'External' box to the top right corner of the 'Well-Being' box.

Critical Assumption

**Internal and external forces
should have similar
consequences across people.**

**People with similar internal and
external forces should have
similar well-being.**

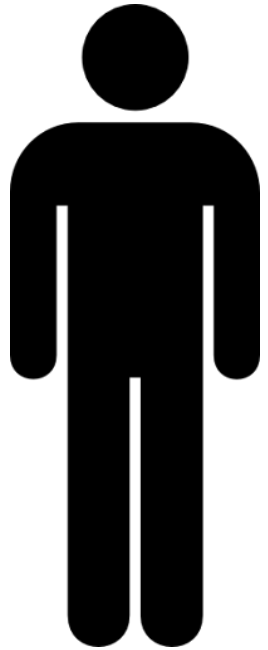
Alternative Assumption

Internal and external forces
should have *different*
consequences across people.

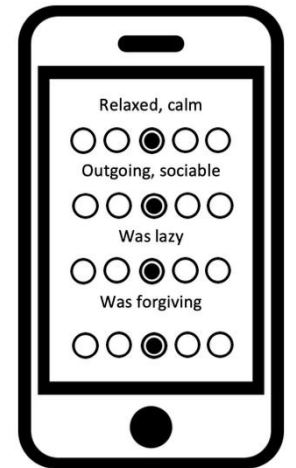
People with similar internal and
external forces *may not* have
similar well-being.

Internal

External



Loneliness



What improves your well-being in the moment?

- Three key findings:
 1. We could predict loneliness reasonably well.
 2. People differ in the extent to which internal versus external factors matter
 3. And people differ in which specific factors—internal or external—matter most

So the antecedents of well-being in the moment are highly idiosyncratic—and as a result, any effective strategies are likely to be as well

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PROBLEM

Most of us are not very good at
changing our emotions like we
want to

What promotes your well-being may change over time

What works will change

You're allowed to adjust

Adjustment is not failure – it's the goal

Thank You!

Materials & Contact



bit.ly/pers-happiness



bit.ly/joy-is-mine



beck-lab.ucdavis.edu



edbeck@ucdavis.edu

Join the Beck Lab!

We're hiring a full-time lab manager to work on two federally funded studies!



Beck Personality Lab



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